

Magic Quadrant for Server Virtualization Platforms

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The server virtualization market faces the most significant disruption in over a decade. Heads of I&O must reevaluate the vendor and technology options for current and future virtual workloads and respond accordingly.

Market Definition/Description

Gartner defines server virtualization platforms as a technology solution that decouples operating systems and workloads from the underlying physical infrastructure. This enables multiple isolated virtual environments to run concurrently across a cluster of hosts while providing centralized management, automation and resource orchestration.

Server virtualization platforms can be used by enterprises to optimize IT infrastructure and improve service levels within data centers and remote locations. Service providers often use a server virtualization platform as an embedded component of their infrastructure as a service (IaaS) offerings and/or for delivering a hosted server virtualization platform.

Key benefits include:

- Improved hardware utilization through the ability to isolate and run multiple virtual workloads on the same physical hardware at the same time.
- Improved reliability, portability and availability through “live migration” of virtual workloads. Related functionality includes the ability to “live migrate” storage and to provide advanced forms of fault tolerance.

- Higher productivity for IT operations through standardized management and integrated administration capabilities for virtual workloads.

Mandatory Features

- **Hypervisor-based virtualization:** Provision of a Type 1 hypervisor that acts as a virtual machine (VM) monitor for hardware resources, including processor and memory. It allows multiple workloads to run simultaneously as VMs on abstracted hardware. Must support x86-based server hardware.
- **Live migration:** The ability to move a running VM to another virtualization host without downtime (referred to as “live migration”).
- **Security:** Role-based access management and integration with external IAM solutions.
- **Management and administration:** Graphical user interface (GUI) for administration of virtual infrastructure, which includes:
 - VMs, hosts, clusters and resource pools
 - Application programming interface (API) for third-party integration of and/or with the server virtualization platform
 - Command line interface (CLI) for automation of the server virtualization platform
- **Storage:** Compatibility with storage protocols such as iSCSI, Fibre Channel, NFS and NVMe over TCP, and virtual disks.
- **Virtual networking:** Support for a virtual network switch that allows VMs to communicate on a specific server or with other servers.

Optional Features

- **Life cycle management:** Patching and upgrades to firmware without virtual machine downtime.
- **Resource scheduler:** Automated balancing of virtual workloads to other virtualization hosts within the platform. Must support policy-based determination of scheduling decisions.
- **Security:** Support for confidential computing; encryption of virtualized compute, storage and network resources; and security of bare-metal infrastructure (firmware, lights out management).

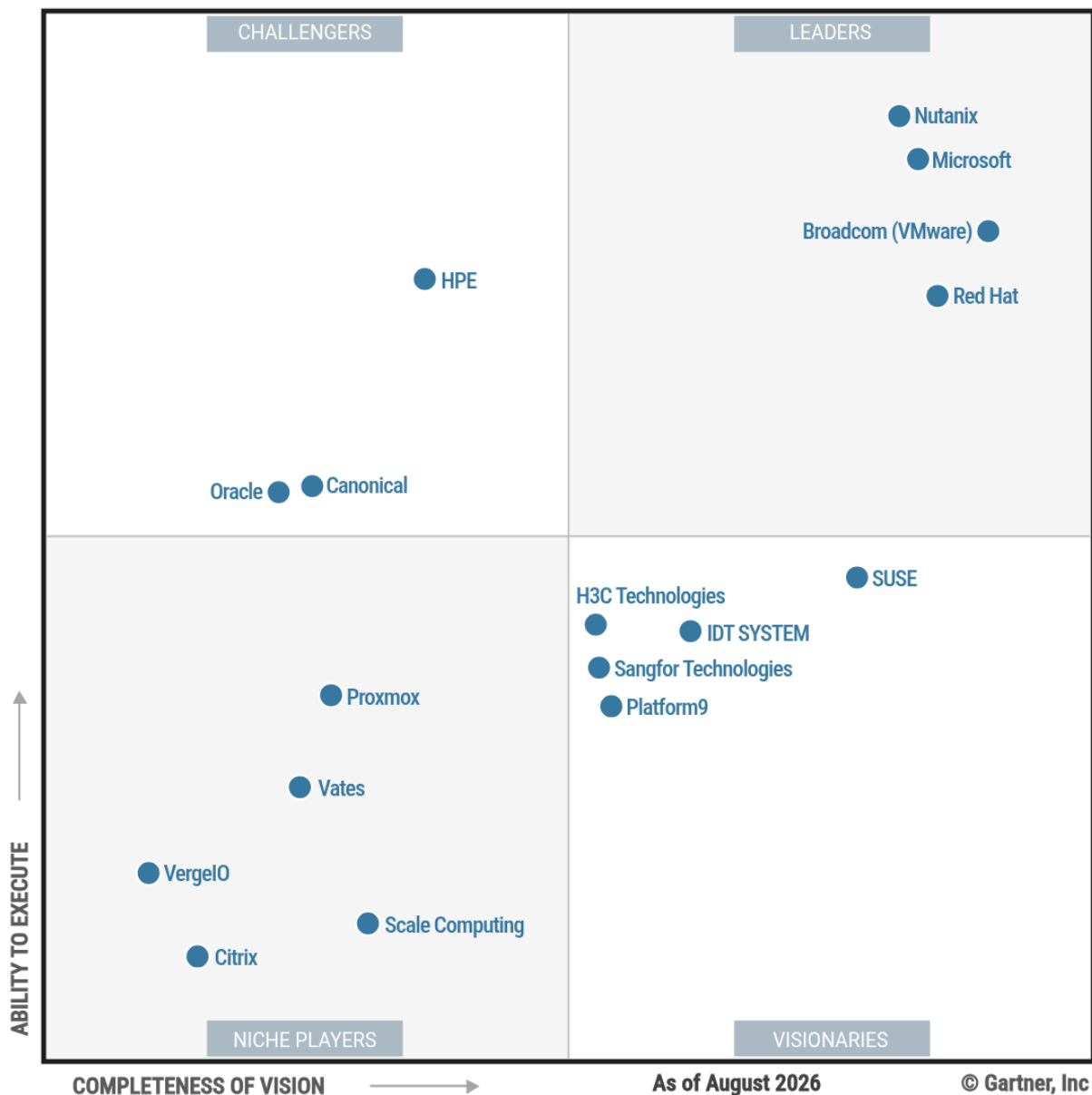
- **Software-defined infrastructure:** Abstraction of storage and/or networking services from the underlying hardware.
- **Data services:** For example, snapshotting, replication, compression, deduplication, live migration of storage.
- **Container-VM convergence:** Integrated support and management of container-based workloads alongside virtual machines.
- **GPU support:** Improved hardware virtualization leading to greater utilization through GPU partitioning and/or resource pools.
- **Additional processor architectures:** Support for non-x86 processors, such as ARM, IBM Power, or RISC-V.

Magic Quadrant

Figure 1: Magic Quadrant for Server Virtualization Platforms



Magic Quadrant for Server Virtualization Platforms



Gartner

Vendor Strengths and Cautions

Broadcom (VMware)

Broadcom is a Leader in this Magic Quadrant. Its VMware Cloud Foundation (VCF) product focuses on unifying compute, storage, networking and Kubernetes into a full-stack private cloud. Its operations are geographically diversified, and its clients range from small businesses to global enterprise businesses in highly regulated verticals such as banking, healthcare and government. Recently, Broadcom released VCF 9.0 with nonvolatile memory express (NVMe) memory tiering and cyber recovery features. Future investments focus on optimizing hardware utilization to alleviate hardware replacement costs, enhancing security against AI-accelerated

threats, embedding AI more comprehensively, and unifying virtual machine (VM) and container workloads.

Strengths

- **Unified full-stack platform:** The release of VCF 9.0 ¹ transforms the offering into a fully integrated enterprise private cloud that combines compute, storage, networking and Kubernetes to enable consistent operations across workloads. IT leaders can capitalize on this deep integration to modernize infrastructure delivery and reduce IT costs.
- **AI integration:** Broadcom has heavily invested in sovereign AI capabilities with graphics processing unit (GPU) virtualization, retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) and fine-tuning capabilities built directly into the VCF platform, enabling enterprises to deploy AI solutions on a familiar platform. Enterprises can take advantage of a consistent operational platform to maximize efficiency for existing and AI workloads.
- **Extensive enterprise ecosystem:** Broadcom's installed base and deep integrations with hardware partners and independent software vendors (ISVs) ensure compatibility for complex IT environments. For organizations in regulated industries that require ISV certification, this ecosystem can provide a safe option.

Cautions

- **Cost increases:** Gartner clients have reported that the transition to per-core subscriptions has resulted in significant cost increases. Many have also reported minimal flexibility during negotiations, which has forced many heads of I&O to actively evaluate migration alternatives.
- **Fewer licensing options:** The shift to a subscription-based VCF model requires customers to purchase the entire stack, including vSAN and NSX. Even though Broadcom offers other solutions, Gartner clients have reported that sales representatives push VCF and NSX.
- **Partner ecosystem disruption:** Broadcom's restructuring of the VMware Cloud Service Provider (VCSP) program and its shift toward direct sales for top accounts have displaced many MSPs and disrupted established channel relationships. Enterprises must reevaluate their current partners to ensure that they can continue to provide support.

Canonical is a Challenger in this Magic Quadrant. Its Canonical OpenStack, MicroCloud, MAAS and LXD products are focused on providing an open-source virtualization stack that combines bare-metal provisioning, private cloud, containers and lightweight distributed edge virtualization. Its operations are geographically diversified, and its clients range from midsize to large enterprises in telecommunications, the public sector and education. Recently, it released MicroCloud and OpenStack updates with native external storage integrations. Future investments include built-in backup and disaster recovery, as well as microVMs to enhance reliability and support modern workloads.

Strengths

- **Predictable node pricing:** Canonical offers transparent, flat per-node pricing, allowing I&O leaders to scale infrastructure with predictable costs.
- **Unified cloud-to-edge platform:** Canonical has invested in a modular architecture that spans MAAS (bare metal), OpenStack (data center) and MicroCloud (data center/edge), providing a consistent operational model across distributed footprints.
- **Long-term security maintenance:** Ubuntu Pro subscriptions provide up to 15 years of support, including security patches, and deliver out-of-the-box compliance for regulated industries that need to meet strict regulatory frameworks such as Federal Information Processing Standards (FIPS) and Center for Internet Security (CIS).

Cautions

- **Perception:** While Ubuntu is well known as a desktop and developer Linux distribution, Canonical's virtualization platform is not widely known in the market.
- **Requires specialized skills:** Operating OpenStack requires a skill shift for infrastructure teams accustomed to managing commercial hypervisors, while MicroCloud and LXD require Linux administration skills. Organizations planning to invest in Canonical solutions will need to invest in training.
- **Enterprise backup support:** Canonical's platform lacks native, certified integrations with major enterprise data protection providers such as Veeam, Rubrik or Commvault, relying instead on niche providers such as Storware and Trilio. Enterprises with existing backup and DR solutions must carefully evaluate the risks of switching providers.

Citrix, owned by Cloud Software Group, is a Niche Player in this Magic Quadrant. Its XenServer SVP provides a cost-efficient platform optimized for Citrix Virtual Apps and Desktops. Its operations are geographically diversified, and its clients range from small service providers to large enterprises in healthcare, financial services and government. Recently, it added NUMA-aware scheduling, host Secure Boot and a verified chain of trust. Future investments include expanding hardware and software partnerships, simplifying the management layer, and enhancing support for general enterprise virtualization.

Strengths

- **VDI workload optimization:** XenServer provides workload-specific optimizations and visibility for Citrix Virtual Apps and Desktops (CVAD). This capability makes the solution an operationally efficient choice for customers with existing Citrix environments.
- **Platform licensing:** Citrix includes XenServer entitlements within its broader Citrix Platform and Universal Hybrid MultiCloud licenses. This inclusion provides excellent TCO for organizations already invested in the ecosystem.
- **Proven reliability:** Citrix runs core virtual desktop infrastructure workloads within healthcare networks and financial institutions, providing technical teams with practical evidence of stability in environments where unexpected downtime is not permitted.

Cautions

- **Narrow market focus:** XenServer is primarily developed and marketed as the underlying engine for Citrix VDI and application virtualization workloads, limiting its appeal as a stand-alone, general-purpose server virtualization replacement.
- **Limited general-purpose capabilities:** Citrix's platform trails market leaders in advanced enterprise features, lacking native software-defined networking (SDN), Border Gateway Protocol (BGP) support and automated storage tiering.
- **Immature backup ecosystem:** Citrix's third-party data protection integrations, such as Zerto and HYCU, remain unavailable or in early access, introducing operational risk for enterprise disaster recovery.

H3C Technologies

H3C Technologies is a Visionary in this Magic Quadrant. Its CAS Server Virtualization Platform is focused on delivering a stable platform featuring lightweight software-defined networking,

intelligent memory overcommit and AI-driven automated operations. Its operations are mostly focused in China, and its clients tend to be large to very large enterprises and public sector organizations in finance, manufacturing and government. Recently, it introduced VM NUMA autobinding and NVMe SSD based memory overcommit. Future investments center on building an intelligent converged cloud platform by synchronizing virtualization with AI compute and vGPU technology.

Strengths

- **Market responsiveness:** H3C responds to enterprise requirements by delivering key market capabilities, including intelligent memory overcommit via NVMe SSDs and vGPU live migration for AI workloads. Organizations should leverage these features to reduce memory costs and extend the life of existing servers.
- **Flexible commercial models:** H3C provides both perpetual licenses and subscription models. Buyers should take advantage of this licensing flexibility to align purchasing models with their needs.
- **Native Kubernetes integration:** H3C CAS offers native integration with Kubernetes through its container cluster service, unifying VM and container resource management. IT leaders focused on modernization can take advantage of this native integration to deliver a single platform for VMs and containers.

Cautions

- **Geographic concentration risk:** The vast majority of H3C's revenue and enterprise footprint are concentrated in China and APAC. Western I&O leaders may face localized support and ecosystem limitations.
- **Limited global partner ecosystem:** The breadth and depth of H3C's ISV and hardware support outside of the Chinese mainland remain significantly constrained. Organizations operating internationally will struggle for ISV support, placing higher burdens on internal IT teams to support and deliver solutions.
- **Storage management:** H3C relies heavily on underlying storage systems for automated tiering and lacks some advanced platform storage features, such as in-line deduplication and compression. Buyers that wish to use H3C as an HCI system should carefully evaluate whether its feature set matches their needs.

HPE is a Challenger in this Magic Quadrant. HPE Morpheus Software includes HPE Morpheus VM Essentials Software, a hardware-agnostic virtualization offering; HPE Morpheus Advanced Software, which adds private cloud automation and Kubernetes support; and HPE Morpheus Enterprise Software, which further adds public cloud and cost management capabilities.

Its operations are geographically diversified, and its clients range from small businesses to global enterprises across healthcare, finance and manufacturing. Recently, HPE added fully automated network provisioning and VM microsegmentation. Future investments include a unified CloudOps platform, multitenancy for AI infrastructure and advanced agentic AI capabilities.

Strengths

- **Multihypervisor management:** HPE's Morpheus platform abstracts complexity through a hardware-agnostic control plane that manages KVM, VMware and public cloud environments under a single operational model.
- **Socket-based pricing:** HPE utilizes socket-based pricing for VM Essentials, allowing users to utilize high-core count CPUs without incurring additional license costs.
- **Agentic AI operations:** HPE's strategic investments in integrating OpsRamp and GreenLake Intelligence aim to shift I&O teams from reactive alert management to intent-driven automation and root-cause remediation. Enterprises should take advantage of these capabilities to reduce operational overhead.

Cautions

- **Software business maturity:** HPE is a new entrant in the SVP market and needs to establish a track record as a major provider of stand-alone virtualization software.
- **Hardware independence:** HPE supports Morpheus Software on servers from multiple vendors; however, HPE's significant server hardware revenue may influence future product decisions that prioritize HPE hardware, potentially affecting multivendor support.
- **GPU live migration:** HPE does not support live migration for VMs with attached GPUs. This limitation may reduce its suitability for on-premises AI solutions that rely on workload mobility.

IDT SYSTEM is a Visionary in this Magic Quadrant. Its InCloud Sphere V8, a full-stack private cloud solution, is focused on providing an enterprise virtualization platform that offers unified management of compute, storage, networking and GPU resources. Its operations are mostly focused in China, and its clients tend to be regional government and public sector organizations, small-to-midsize enterprises (SMEs) and large enterprises in the finance, energy, transportation and manufacturing sectors. Recently, it added cross-cloud VM migration and tiered memory overcommitment using NVMe SSDs. Future investments focus on supporting mixed workloads of VMs, containers and bare metal for AI inference models, alongside expanding its global presence.

Strengths

- **Flexible platform:** IDT SYSTEM can support core virtualization capabilities through its InCloud Sphere platform while also providing InCloud AIOS to support mixed workloads, including bare-metal servers and containers. Organizations can adopt the capabilities they need without purchasing bundled functionality they do not require.
- **Market understanding:** IDT SYSTEM has demonstrated a clear understanding of enterprise needs for large-scale enterprise migrations with compressed time frames. Enterprises planning a new hypervisor migration can take advantage of this proven capability.
- **Pricing:** IDT SYSTEM maintains a highly predictable, budget-friendly software business model centered on socket-based perpetual licensing that excludes per-VM or incremental core-based license cost increases.

Cautions

- **Narrow geographic market focus:** IDT SYSTEM's customer base is 93% in China and has no market presence in North America or Latin America. Buyers that require international support should assess the consistency of sales and support capabilities for each region.
- **Fragmented support infrastructure:** IDT SYSTEM delivers Level 1 technical support through local partner networks, confines Level 2 assistance to centralized hubs in Hong Kong and Southeast Asia, and relies on remote R&D engineering teams in China for Level 3 troubleshooting. This multitiered topology can introduce communication delays and increase resolution times during critical system outages.
- **Security hardening:** IDT SYSTEM does not provide security-hardening guidelines aligned with common international standards and frameworks, such as China MPLS, CIS

Benchmarks and NIST guidelines. Enterprises must develop their own hardening guidelines and scripts, potentially increasing security and operational risks.

Microsoft

Microsoft is a Leader in this Magic Quadrant. Its Azure Local and Windows Server 2025 Hyper-V products are broadly focused on delivering a cloud-native virtualization platform, with Azure serving as the unified control plane across data centers and the edge. Its operations are geographically diversified, and its clients range from startups to global enterprises in financial services, healthcare and government. Recently, Microsoft made full Fibre Channel storage support generally available (GA) for Azure Local, enabling large clusters, and introduced Azure Arc-enabled hot patching for Windows Server 2025. Future investments include enhancing AI infrastructure, expanding management capabilities through Azure Arc and increasing support for sovereign cloud scenarios.

Strengths

- **Hybrid capabilities:** Microsoft's Azure Arc provides a unified control plane for on-premises Windows Server Hyper-V and Azure Local environments alongside Azure cloud services, enabling a common management infrastructure across on-premises and cloud deployments. Enterprises should take advantage of this commonality to reduce operation costs.
- **Ecosystem integrations:** Microsoft offers a large, fully certified ecosystem of enterprise backup, monitoring, security and other ISV integrations, reducing operational risk.
- **Hardware-rooted security:** Microsoft continues to invest heavily in infrastructure security through secured-core server capabilities, confidential computing, shielded VMs and GPU partitioning (GPU-P) for safe AI workload execution. Organizations that must meet strict sovereignty and risk compliance laws, such as DORA or FedRAMP High, should take advantage of these capabilities.

Cautions

- **Management tools:** Administrators must navigate multiple disjointed management consoles, including Azure Portal, Windows Admin Center and System Center Virtual Machine Manager, to perform routine operational tasks.
- **Azure dependency:** Hybrid capabilities, such as Azure Virtual Desktop on Windows Server 2025 or AKS on Azure Local, are tied to the Azure cloud, increasing an organization's

reliance on Microsoft as its cloud provider.

- **Patching:** The frequency, volume and size of Microsoft's Windows Server patches continue to frustrate administrators by extending maintenance windows and increasing the risk of unplanned cluster disruptions.

Nutanix

Nutanix is a Leader in this Magic Quadrant. Its Nutanix Cloud Infrastructure (NCI) product is broadly focused on providing a unified hybrid cloud platform that combines compute, networking, storage and a hypervisor for VMs and containers. Its operations are geographically diversified, and its clients range from midsize to large enterprises in the public sector, financial services and healthcare. Recently, it expanded NCI to support external storage platforms from Dell PowerStore and Everpure (formerly Pure Storage). Future investments include expanding its hardware ecosystem through new storage partnerships, with NetApp currently in preview, and developing an agentic AI solution with topology-aware GPU scheduling.

Strengths

- **Platform maturity:** Nutanix is a mature solution with a large installed base, a reputation for operational simplicity and a consistently high customer satisfaction rating. Organizations can leverage its tightly integrated platform to deliver operational efficiency at scale.
- **Cloud-based IaaS:** Nutanix Cloud Clusters (NC2) allows organizations to run identical infrastructure across on-premises environments, Amazon Web Services (AWS), Azure and Google Cloud Platform (GCP) without refactoring applications.
- **Expanded storage flexibility:** Nutanix recently added support for disaggregated deployments that use external storage platforms, including Dell PowerStore and Everpure, while continuing to qualify additional solutions. Organizations can leverage these capabilities to reuse existing hardware and reduce the transition costs.

Cautions

- **Premium pricing:** Gartner clients report that licensing can be complex and pricing frequently exceeds expectations. Clients should carefully evaluate the ROI of potential migrations.
- **Limited external storage options:** Nutanix only supports NFS and NVMe/TCP as storage protocols for disaggregated deployments, and its vendor support is limited. Enterprises

with a large installed base of Fibre Channel storage, or an array that Nutanix does not currently support, should carefully evaluate the roadmap for future storage support.

- **Hardware support:** Nutanix supports specific server models and configurations from approved vendors. While Nutanix continues to expand its supported hardware ecosystem, its HCL does not permit organizations to build a certified server from individually certified components. This restriction can limit the reuse of existing hardware and potentially increase migration costs.

Oracle

Oracle is a Challenger in this Magic Quadrant. Its Oracle Virtualization product is broadly focused on providing an enterprise virtualization platform optimized for Oracle workloads, hybrid cloud operations and software licensing compliance. Its operations are geographically diversified, and its clients tend to be midsize, large and global enterprises in government, healthcare, financial services and telecommunications. Recently, it expanded Windows enterprise workload support and introduced Keycloak integration for identity and access management. Future investments include VMware migration automation, hybrid VM and Kubernetes operational convergence, and continued AI infrastructure improvements, including GPU virtualization.

Strengths

- **Proven resilience and scalability:** Oracle Cloud and Exadata Cloud@Customer use the Oracle hypervisor, which has a long track record of hosting large-scale workloads, especially Oracle databases.
- **Hard partitioning compliance:** Oracle is the only x86 virtualization platform that Oracle recognizes for hard partitioning of its products, including Oracle Database. This capability helps customers reduce licensing costs by licensing only the cores needed to run Oracle workloads. Oracle Database customers should take advantage of this capability to reduce licensing costs.
- **License model:** Each license entitles up to two sockets in the same server. For most environments, this model functions as a per-host license. Organizations incur no additional licensing costs for large core-count CPUs or large-memory footprint systems, lowering costs in these environments.

Cautions

- **Brand perception:** Many enterprises hesitate to commit to an Oracle platform due to concerns, raised by Gartner clients, regarding Oracle's behavior during traditional on-premises software sales. This perception limits broader market adoption and reinforces the view that the platform is only viable for organizations already invested in Oracle products.
- **Catch-up roadmap:** The vendor's roadmap focuses on baseline feature parity, which limits its ability to innovate in the SVP market. Buyers should be clear on what feature set they expect and whether Oracle Virtualization can meet those features.
- **Limited full-stack capabilities:** Oracle Virtualization provides robust core virtualization functionality, but does not provide an integrated full-stack solution. Although the Oracle Linux Premier Plus license includes access to other products such as Oracle Cloud Native Environment and Oracle Linux Automation Manager, these do not integrate directly with Oracle Virtualization and require separate management consoles.

Platform9

Platform9 is a Visionary in this Magic Quadrant. Its Private Cloud Director product is broadly focused on offering a hardware-agnostic virtualization and container management platform with a SaaS-delivered control plane and automated migration tooling. Its operations are focused in North America, with a growing presence in Europe. Its clients tend to be midsize to large enterprises and service providers in telecommunications, manufacturing and healthcare. Recently, it introduced GPU acceleration for VMs and Layer 2 networking. Future investments target enhanced networking, security, live migration for vGPU VMs, Kubernetes autoscaling, private AI inference workload management and AI-native user experiences.

Strengths

- **Hardware reuse:** Platform9 is optimized for reusing existing servers, storage and networks. It integrates with existing enterprise storage arrays and Fibre Channel SANs through standard block storage APIs, reducing migration costs.
- **In-place migration:** The vJailbreak tool automates cluster conversion to Platform9 on existing hardware, eliminating the need for expensive swing gear. Organizations with limited budgets can take advantage of this capability to reduce the cost of switching hypervisors.
- **Multitenancy:** Private Cloud Director has native constructs for domains, tenants and regions, along with a user self-service portal that provides resource metering and billing.

These capabilities simplify deployment in multitenant environments.

Cautions

- **Requires storage arrays:** Platform9 does not incorporate native software-defined storage (SDS) capabilities within its virtualization platform. Clients migrating from an HCI architecture will need to invest in external storage.
- **GPU virtualization:** Private Cloud Director does not support out-of-the-box live migration for VMs that use vGPU (hardware-based GPU sharing). This limitation currently reduces its suitability for on-premises AI solutions that require workload migration.
- **Market presence:** Platform9's status as a private entity with a smaller user base limits its corporate resources and global channel reach compared to larger incumbents. Consequently, heads of I&O may need extended evaluation periods when assessing regional support capabilities and long-term business viability.

Proxmox

Proxmox is a Niche Player in this Magic Quadrant. Its Proxmox Virtual Environment product is broadly focused on delivering an open-source platform that supports KVM-based VMs and Linux Containers (LXC) with integrated storage. Proxmox's operations are geographically diversified, and its clients range from SMBs to large enterprises in the retail, government, banking and education sectors. Recently, it introduced Proxmox Datacenter Manager for multicluster management, dynamic load balancing and general ARM architecture support. Future investments center on improving the Cluster Resource Scheduler, adding general ARM support for AI deployments, enhancing storage management through the GUI, and adding more resellers and OEMs to the Proxmox Solution Provider Program.

Strengths

- **Fully open source:** Proxmox's full enterprise stack is freely downloadable, available to all users without a license. Users can test and evaluate the platform without starting a sales process and incurring license cost.
- **Native VM and container support:** Proxmox natively integrates KVM-based VMs with lightweight LXC containers. This integration allows I&O teams to run diverse workloads on a single platform without overhead.

- **Sovereignty:** Proxmox is headquartered in the EU, making it one of the few options available to companies that must buy critical infrastructure only from EU-flagged entities. Its full auditable open-source base further enhances sovereign infrastructure requirements.

Cautions

- **Limited support:** Even at its highest subscription tier, Proxmox ² provides support only through email during business hours. Enterprise IT organizations should carefully evaluate whether this model meets their support requirements.
- **Missing ISV certifications:** Proxmox lacks formal ISV certifications from major independent software vendors such as Oracle or SAP. This missing credential can block adoption for mission-critical enterprise applications.
- **Limited operations scale:** Proxmox employs 100 FTEs and operates at a smaller operational scale than larger providers in this market. Organizations with highly distributed global deployments should assess its ability to support their requirements.

Red Hat

Red Hat is a Leader in this Magic Quadrant. Its Red Hat OpenShift Virtualization product is broadly focused on running VMs natively inside containers, using KubeVirt to unify VMs, containers and serverless workloads on a single Kubernetes platform. Red Hat is a wholly owned subsidiary of IBM, and its operations are geographically diversified; its clients tend to be large enterprises in financial services, manufacturing, telecommunications and the public sector. Recently, it added a dedicated virtualization administrator view within the OpenShift console and introduced cross-cluster live migration capabilities. Future investments focus on enhancing VM administration, delivering hard multitenancy for managed service providers (MSPs), and integrating AI services.

Strengths

- **Kubernetes-first architecture:** VMs and containers operate together on the same Kubernetes platform, sharing a common API, scheduler, role-based access control (RBAC) framework, open virtual network (OVN) networking and GitOps workflows. Organizations can use this architecture to simplify integration with infrastructure-as-code (IaC) pipelines across both containers and VMs.
- **DevOps enablement:** Red Hat's OpenShift platform includes architecture and tools that align well with modern DevOps practices. These capabilities can accelerate deployment of

new applications for customers and provide a platform for modernizing legacy applications.

- **Broad public cloud partnerships:** OpenShift Virtualization is available across multiple public clouds, including AWS, Azure and GCP. Enterprises with multicloud requirements can leverage these partnerships to migrate workloads across cloud and on-premises environments.

Cautions

- **Steep learning curve:** Red Hat's platform requires traditional VM administrators to adopt Kubernetes-centric paradigms, creating a significant skills gap and increasing retraining requirements. Enterprises adopting Red Hat's platform will need to invest in training and skills development.
- **Complex commercial bundling:** Gartner clients report high initial subscription costs, renewal increases and additional support requirements, which can increase costs for organizations that use the platform primarily as a VM replacement solution.
- **Delivery capacity constraints:** Red Hat's direct sales and delivery capacity remains constrained, resulting in heavy reliance on GSIs, SIs and MSPs for migration execution. This dependency can delay migrations and increase costs for organizations that require a rapid migration.

Sangfor Technologies

Sangfor Technologies is a Visionary in this Magic Quadrant. Its Sangfor HCI and aSV products are broadly focused on delivering a modular hyperconverged solution that covers server virtualization, network virtualization, shared storage and native built-in security. Its operations are mostly focused in China and APAC, and its clients tend to be midsize to large enterprises in government, healthcare, banking, retail and manufacturing. Recently, it introduced memory tiering and NVMe over RoCEv2 storage support. Future investments target unified resource pooling for CPUs and GPUs from different vendors, certification of additional third-party backup and disaster recovery ISVs, and enhanced fault-tolerance features.

Strengths

- **License flexibility:** Sangfor offers both perpetual and subscription-based licenses. Buyers should take advantage of this flexibility to align licensing with their purchasing requirements.

- **Architecture diversity:** In addition to Intel and AMD x86 processors, the Sangfor HCI platform supports ARM and Hygon x86 processors. Enterprises with a multi-CPU architecture strategy, generally driven by AI, can take advantage of a single virtualization platform, simplifying operations.
- **Feature velocity:** Over the past year, Sangfor has rapidly pivoted its roadmap to prioritize feature parity with other platforms and support for external storage. Organizations should take advantage of its continued platform innovation to address evolving infrastructure requirements.

Cautions

- **Geographic presence:** Approximately 80% of Sangfor's customer base is in China and APAC. While Sangfor is actively growing business in EMEA, international buyers should assess whether local sales and support capabilities meet their needs.
- **Management and ecosystem integration:** Sangfor lacks the broad certified partner ecosystem available from many leading vendors. This limitation may restrict adoption in regulated industries that require ISV-certified solutions.
- **Security and compliance maturity:** Sangfor does not provide guidance for hardening systems to meet compliance frameworks. As a result, organizations in regulated industries may face limitations when deploying the platform.

Scale Computing

Scale Computing is a Niche Player in this Magic Quadrant. Its SC//HyperCore suite delivers a simple, self-healing hyperconverged infrastructure platform that combines AIME automation, the SCRIBE storage layer, compute, storage and a KVM-based hypervisor for data center and edge deployments. A subsidiary of Acumera, Scale Computing operates globally and primarily serves small and midsize businesses and distributed enterprises in retail, manufacturing, education and healthcare. Recently, it added native Veeam backup integration, a Terraform provider, and automated node life cycle management. Future investments include a fully managed Kubernetes container runtime, a native Container Storage Interface (CSI) driver and expanded hardware support.

Strengths

- **Distributed fleet management:** SC//Fleet Manager provides a cloud-based management interface that orchestrates, monitors and updates anywhere from one to 10,000+ clusters

simultaneously. Organizations can use these capabilities to simplify management across large edge deployments.

- **Zero-touch deployment:** Scale Computing's zero-touch deployment capabilities and SecureLink connectivity enable remote device deployment without requiring a VPN. Organizations can deploy systems at remote locations without relying on specialized on-site engineering staff.
- **Minimal hardware requirements:** SC//HyperCore's minimal resource requirements enable the use of lightweight ruggedized industrial PCs and NUCs, reducing costs for edge deployments.

Cautions

- **Focus:** Scale Computing's recent acquisition by Acumera and the 2026 acquisition of Adaptiv Networks could divert R&D funding from core virtualization platforms into managed retail security bundles. Businesses looking for a hypervisor replacement should carefully evaluate the product roadmap.
- **Scalability:** Scale Computing's maximum cluster size of eight nodes makes large-scale data center deployments impractical. Organizations with larger virtualization requirements should ensure that a federated cluster solution will match their operational needs.
- **Geographic presence:** Scale Computing has limited brand awareness outside its core markets and lacks extensive local support infrastructure in some regions. Because the company delivers support primarily through resellers, organizations may experience longer resolution times for complex issues.

SUSE

SUSE is a Visionary in this Magic Quadrant. Its SUSE Virtualization and SUSE Rancher Prime products are broadly focused on providing a cloud-native platform that runs VMs within Kubernetes pods via a turnkey bare-metal appliance with value-based pricing. Its operations are geographically diversified, and its clients range from midsize to large enterprises in government, telecommunications and financial services. Recently, it introduced support for external SAN and NAS storage alongside VM Auto Balance for rebalancing VM workloads across clusters. Future plans include developing a multitenant cloud portal with automated billing and advancing distributed workload mobility and hybrid cloud networking.

Strengths

- **VM and container convergence:** SUSE's platform offers unified management for containers and VMs with virtualization integrated directly into the Kubernetes control plane. Clients modernizing to cloud-native platforms can manage containers and VMs through a single interface, simplifying operations.
- **Sovereignty:** SUSE is headquartered in the EU, making it one of the few options available to companies that must buy critical infrastructure only from EU-flagged entities. Its fully open-source and auditable foundation further enhances sovereign requirements.
- **Enterprise security and compliance capabilities:** SUSE offers strong security features for access control, authentication, data protection and monitoring, along with comprehensive hardening guidance for secure deployments.

Cautions

- **Management and operational maturity:** Some key management and operations capabilities, such as cluster-to-cluster migration, are either missing or still in experimental stages. Buyers should carefully evaluate whether the available feature set meets their needs.
- **Availability and recovery capabilities:** While SUSE Virtualization provides native VM backup and restore capabilities, it lacks broad native disaster recovery orchestration. For DR capabilities, SUSE relies on partners and ecosystem tooling. Enterprises with existing backup and DR tooling should verify that their solutions operate with SUSE Virtualization.
- **Cloud-native focus:** SUSE places significant emphasis on cloud-native environments, which could reduce investment focus on stand-alone virtualization capabilities for traditional IT organizations. Buyers should evaluate the product roadmap to ensure that future enhancements align with their requirements and delivery expectations.

Vates

Vates is a Niche Player in this Magic Quadrant. Its Vates Virtualization Management Stack is focused on delivering an open-source platform utilizing the Xen-based XCP-ng hypervisor and Xen Orchestra for enterprise virtualization and integrated backup. Its operations are geographically diversified, and its clients tend to be SMBs and large enterprises in government, technology, telecommunications and education. Recently, it introduced Xen Orchestra 6.0 and natively integrated QCOW2 virtual disk support. Future investments include

modernizing the XCP-ng 9 architecture, advancing software-defined networking with microsegmentation and enhancing the Xen Orchestra 6 user experience.

Strengths

- **Per-host licensing:** Vates' XCP-ng uses flat per-host pricing, eliminating per-socket and per-core license penalties. Organizations can deploy systems with higher core and socket counts without increasing licensing costs.
- **Automation and DevOps:** For IaC developers, Vates offers SDKs for Go, PowerShell and Python, along with Swagger-compatible APIs. For Kubernetes developers, Project Pyrgos deploys a turnkey cluster based on Canonical MicroK8s, with recommended best practices enabled directly from the Xen Orchestra GUI.
- **Sovereignty:** Vates is headquartered in the EU, making it one of the few options available to companies that must buy critical infrastructure only from EU-flagged entities. Its fully open-source and auditable foundation further enhances sovereign requirements.

Cautions

- **XCP-ng support and adoption:** XCP-ng is not widely used, which impacts the availability of certifications and ISV support. Users should verify support for required applications, backup solutions and disaster recovery tools before adoption.
- **Efficiency:** XCP-ng does not support true memory oversubscription, and it provides limited CPU oversubscription. Coupled with the overhead associated with Dom0 in Xen architectures, XCP-ng may struggle to achieve maximum hardware utilization, potentially increasing hardware costs.
- **Encryption:** Vates' optional XOSTOR SDS feature does not currently support encryption at rest for VM images or files. Clients in regulated industries that require encryption will need additional solutions to prevent compliance and audit challenges.

VergelO

VergelO is a Niche Player in this Magic Quadrant. Its VergeOS product is focused on providing a Private Cloud OS that consolidates compute, storage, networking and disaster recovery into a single codebase with per-physical-server licensing. Its operations are mostly focused in North America, and its clients tend to be midsize to large enterprises and MSPs in telecommunications, education, finance and healthcare. Recently, it added NVIDIA Multi-

Instance GPU support and oVirt API compatibility. Future investments focus on native container support, stretched clusters for active-active workloads and next-generation VergeFS for deeper resiliency.

Strengths

- **Pricing model:** Verge uses a node-based licensing scheme that reduces software licensing overhead compared with core-based platforms. Organizations can also reuse existing server assets by avoiding unnecessary hardware refreshes and lowering overall costs.
- **Storage resilience:** Verge products focus on storage resilience through capabilities, such as ioProtect for multisite replication, ioReplicate for DR orchestration and ioClone for immutable VM hard disk snapshots. Organizations can eliminate the need for third-party disaster recovery orchestration and storage replication software.
- **Ransomware protection:** Verge's ioFortify function creates immutable, restorable checkpoints of virtual data centers and provides proactive ransomware detection alerts. These capabilities reduce attack exposure and enable rapid recovery with minimal downtime and data loss.

Cautions

- **Innovation:** Verge lacks native continuous dynamic VM load balancing, hot-add capabilities for vCPU and memory, and native iSCSI or NFS storage support. Buyers should evaluate the product roadmap and the company's ability to deliver key features.
- **Operations:** Verge operates with a smaller support organization and overall operational scale than many larger providers in this market. Organizations with highly distributed global deployments should carefully assess its operational processes and support capabilities.
- **Geographic presence:** Verge has limited international brand awareness, and 80% of its current customer base resides in North America. While the company continues to expand into other regions, international buyers should assess whether locally available sales and support capabilities meet their needs.

Inclusion and Exclusion Criteria

Magic Quadrants and Critical Capabilities identify and analyze the most relevant providers and their products in a market. The inclusion criteria are the specific attributes that a provider must

have to be included in this research. In addition to Gartner client relevance, as determined by analyst expertise and opinion,

providers need to meet the following criteria to qualify for inclusion:

1. Must sell a server virtualization platform (SVP) offering aligning to the SVP market definition. All mandatory features must be generally available as of 1 May 2026.
2. Regions: All SVP offerings must have at least 10 production customers per region in at least 4 out of 7 regions (North America, Europe, Asia Pacific (excluding China), Latin America, China, Middle East, and Africa).
3. Sell the solution directly to paying customers without requiring them to engage professional services help. The vendor must provide, but is not limited to, comprehensive product documentation, installation guidance, reference examples, phone and/or email and/or Web support.
4. They must offer contract, console/portal, technical documentation and customer support in English (either as the product's default language or as an optional localization).
5. Must be the primary developer and IP owner of the software components of the SVP (control plane, management software and hypervisor) with an exception for open-source based products. Solutions based on open-source projects must be able to show either:
 1. Unique IP that adds customer-valued features above and beyond the base open-source solution, OR
 2. Be among the top 10 contributors to the core open-source project.
6. Ability to address 4 out of 6 use cases defined in the Critical Capabilities. We may update the inclusion criteria during the research process.

Exclusion Criteria

Offerings are excluded from this Critical Capabilities research if they are:

- Exclusively marketed and sold as container management infrastructure products and cannot accommodate virtual machine infrastructure.

Offerings are excluded from this market if they are not:

- Fully customer controlled with direct access to and management of the hypervisor layer

- Able to operate independently of any public cloud, without any external network connection or continuous metering of core virtualization functions.

Honorable Mentions

Gartner tracks more than 40 vendors in this market. Seventeen vendors met the inclusion criteria for this Magic Quadrant, but the exclusion of a vendor does not mean that the vendor and its products lack viability. The following noteworthy vendors did not meet all inclusion criteria, but offer specialized capabilities for specific deployment patterns.

Huawei: Huawei's FusionCompute platform provides compute, storage and network virtualization, including features such as live VM migration and dynamic resource scheduling. Huawei's Data Center Virtualization Solution (DCS) adds disaster recovery (DR) and data management capabilities. Huawei's platforms benefit from the co-design of hardware and software, and they are extremely popular within China.

Oxide Computing: Oxide Computer Company's innovative integrated rack-scale compute delivers a co-designed hardware and software solution that the company rebuilt from the firmware layer upward as a fully open-source solution. Its custom virtualization stack is derived from the open-source bhyve hypervisor and Propolis, Oxide's Rust-based userspace VMM. Oxide is focused on delivering cloud-style operations at scale.

StorMagic: StorMagic's KVM-based SvHCI hyperconverged, hypervisor-agnostic SvSAN SDS and Edge Control fleet management solutions are designed for widely distributed small systems with strong requirements for resilience and data protection, such as in retail stores, healthcare, transportation, energy and manufacturing. Its focus on two-node edge solutions limits its use outside of the edge use case.

Evaluation Criteria

The Ability to Execute criteria for this Magic Quadrant are as follows:

Product or Service: This criterion assesses a vendor's ability to deliver and differentiate features and functionality that support most market use cases, as well as the diversification of customer use across the vendor's portfolio.

Overall Viability: This criterion assesses a vendor's key financial, staffing and customer base growth metrics.

Sales Execution/Pricing: This criterion assesses a vendor’s success in the market. Considerations include results of new versus repeat business, growth in new SVP customers and changes in customer investments. The evaluation also considers adaptations to sales and presales efforts and the level of pricing transparency.

Market Responsiveness/Record: This criterion evaluates the vendor’s ability to deliver SVP products and capabilities that are first to market and differentiate the vendor from competitors, while continuing to meet market demands and address gaps in its portfolio.

Marketing Execution: This criterion evaluates the vendor’s ability to create mind share, expand into new markets and build a sales pipeline.

Customer Experience: This criterion evaluates the vendor’s ability to demonstrate continued client satisfaction and improvement, and to provide distinct customer support capabilities. It also evaluates how the vendor is perceived in the market and how well the market recognizes its marketing programs. The evaluation focuses on how effectively the vendor influences and shapes market perception through marketing activities and thought leadership that drive awareness. An additional indicator for this criterion is how often Gartner clients inquire about a specific vendor’s capabilities or reputation, or include the vendor in a shortlist evaluation process.

Operations: This criterion evaluates the vendor’s ability to meet goals and commitments. Factors include the quality of the organizational structure, skills and relationships, as well as the vendor’s ability to meet SLAs. Considerations include partnerships with other technology providers, customer-facing outages and SLA adherence.

Ability to Execute

Ability to Execute Evaluation Criteria	
<i>Evaluation Criteria</i>	<i>Weighting</i>
Product or Service	High
Overall Viability	High
Sales Execution/Pricing	High

<i>Evaluation Criteria</i>	<i>Weighting</i>
Market Responsiveness/Record	High
Marketing Execution	High
Customer Experience	High
Operations	Low

Source: Gartner (September 2026)

Completeness of Vision

The Completeness of Vision criteria for this Magic Quadrant are as follows:

Market Understanding: This criterion evaluates the vendor's ability to understand customer requirements, align those requirements with its products and services, and evolve its product vision based on its established perspectives of the market's direction.

Sales Strategy: This criterion evaluates the vendor's ability to establish and update a sales strategy that aligns with company goals and customer interest. Factors include the vendor's ability to reach customers directly and provide coverage through its network of partners.

Offering (Product) Strategy: This criterion evaluates the vendor's product planning, emphasizing its alignment with market shortcomings, commitment to differentiation and improvement of existing capabilities.

Business Model: This criterion evaluates the vendor's strategies to sustain its business in the market.

Vertical/Industry Strategy: This criterion evaluates the vendor's strategy to direct its product offerings, align with industry-specific technology providers and allocate resources to meet specific vertical-market requirements.

Innovation: This criterion evaluates plans for delivering future differentiated capabilities that enhance the vendor's ability to interact with customers and drive business. It also evaluates

the vendor’s strategy for reinvestment and its differentiating innovations in product design and capabilities, the introduction of new technologies, third-party partner relationships, integration, and overall differentiation in the SVP market.

Geographic Strategy: This criterion evaluates the vendor’s strategy to direct resources, skills and product offerings to meet customer needs across the major geographic regions.

Completeness of Vision Evaluation Criteria	
<i>Evaluation Criteria</i>	<i>Weighting</i>
Market Understanding	High
Marketing Strategy	NotRated
Sales Strategy	Low
Offering (Product) Strategy	High
Business Model	Medium
Vertical/Industry Strategy	Low
Innovation	High
Geographic Strategy	Low

Source: Gartner (September 2026)

Quadrant Descriptions

Leaders

Leaders exhibit strong execution and vision scores and have proven success in the market by gaining market share. In the SVP market, Leaders have successfully shown they can attract

clients by addressing a broad range of enterprise use cases from basic virtualization to private cloud solutions and AI workloads. Leaders have established scale across multiple global regions. They bring continuous innovation to their offerings, such as advanced automation and predictive resource scaling, and make significant investments in their SVP capabilities to address evolving enterprise demands.

Challengers

Challengers exhibit a strong set of technologies, marketing and sales execution, and intellectual property, similar to Leaders, but they are limited in their user base. For example, a Challenger in the SVP market might possess a highly robust platform, but its operations may be limited to its own hardware or customer base. Challengers may be satisfied with serving their current customer base or market, or they may lack the strategic support, broader vision, or desire to compete in the overall enterprise market represented by the Leaders quadrant.

Visionaries

Visionaries exhibit strong capabilities in their current offerings and a complete set of functionalities to address common use cases. However, the vendor's size, installed-base size, platform breadth or integration points may make its platform appropriate for some, but not all, enterprise buyers. Visionary SVP capabilities include advanced AI-assisted operations, sovereign cloud architectures or a significant regional base. Visionaries have the opportunity to scale, support all industry verticals, and achieve global reach, even if their current operational execution or market share lags behind that of Leaders.

Niche Players

Niche Players exhibit leadership in specific use cases, market segments, regions or verticals. However, their offerings fail to provide a breadth of features that make them relevant to all buyers. Characteristics observed in Niche Players for this SVP Magic Quadrant include a dominant focus on specific regional markets or industry verticals.

Context

The SVP market has been reinvigorated by Broadcom's acquisition of VMware. Licensing changes, forced bundling and evolving vendor strategies have reshaped the market, alongside shifts in infrastructure economics and the integration of AI functionality into

virtualization platforms. As organizations reassess their long-term virtualization investments, many are evaluating alternative platforms that provide comparable functionality while offering greater flexibility, reduced operational complexity or a lower total cost of ownership. This reassessment has accelerated competition among commercial vendors, cloud providers and open-source ecosystems seeking to establish themselves as strategic infrastructure platforms.

In today's market environment, organizations are evaluating a diverse range of server virtualization solutions that vary in architecture, ecosystem integration and operating model. Established virtualization vendors continue to enhance platform capabilities through integrated management, automation, security, cloud interoperability and the addition of AI capabilities. At the same time, newer market entrants are driving innovation through open-source virtualization technologies, hyperconverged infrastructure integration and tighter alignment with cloud-native operating models.

Market Overview

The SVP market helps organizations improve server utilization, increase operational efficiency and deliver reliable compute services across data center, edge and cloud environments. SVPs use hypervisor-based virtualization to abstract physical server resources, allowing multiple VMs to run on shared hardware. This capability helps organizations use infrastructure more efficiently while providing a consistent platform for deploying and managing workloads.

Enterprises use SVPs to modernize data center operations, support business-critical applications, simplify infrastructure management and build private cloud environments. Service providers also use these platforms as a foundation for infrastructure as a service (IaaS) and hosted virtualization offerings. As a result, server virtualization remains a core technology within many private cloud, hybrid cloud and enterprise infrastructure strategies.

The market is characterized by platforms that combine virtualization capabilities with centralized management, security, automation and operational controls. Key capabilities typically include workload portability through live migration, resource optimization, infrastructure resiliency, and integration with storage, networking and identity management systems. Many platforms also support software-defined infrastructure services and the management of both VM- and container-based workloads.

As organizations continue to modernize infrastructure and operate across multiple environments, SVPs remain a foundational layer of enterprise IT. They provide a common platform for running, managing and securing workloads while helping organizations balance operational consistency, performance, scalability and cost-efficiency across their infrastructure estate.

Note 1: VCF Release

VCF 9.1 was released on 12 May 2026 after the evaluation cutoff date for this Magic Quadrant.

Note 2: Proxmox Support

Proxmox announced future 24hr support after the evaluation cutoff date for this Magic Quadrant.

⊕ Evaluation Criteria Definitions

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